# THE ZETA FUNCTION OF AN ELLIPTIC CURVE

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Section 1 defines the zeta function of a curve over $\mathbb{F}_q$ as a generating function for its numbers of rational points, and shows that it is also an Euler product over the closed points of the curve. Section 2 computes the zeta function of an elliptic curve $E$ from the action of Frobenius on the Tate module, proves the Riemann hypothesis for it, and deduces Hasse's bound $|\#E(\mathbb{F}_q) - q - 1| \leqslant 2\sqrt{q}$. Section 3 shows that the zeta function, equivalently the single number $\#E(\mathbb{F}_q)$, is a complete isogeny invariant. Each problem is preceded by the definitions and results it uses.

**Reading.** [Sil09, §V.2], with [Sil09, §§III.7–III.8] for the Tate module, and [Poo06, §§2.2.1 and 3.4–3.5] for closed points and the Euler product. Three of the problems are exercises from [Sil09, Chapter V]: Problem 2.1 is Exercise 5.3, Problem 2.9 is Exercise 5.13 and Problem 3.4 is Exercise 5.4.

`Magma`**.** If you have no local installation, every block below runs in the free online calculator.

**Standing notation.**

- A power $q = p^r$ of a prime $p$, and the Galois group $\mathrm{Gal}_{\mathbb{F}_q} = \mathrm{Gal}(\overline{\mathbb{F}}_q/\mathbb{F}_q)$.
- The automorphism $\sigma \in \mathrm{Gal}_{\mathbb{F}_q}$, $t \mapsto t^q$, of $\overline{\mathbb{F}}_q$, which generates $\mathrm{Gal}_{\mathbb{F}_q}$ topologically. Its fixed field in $\overline{\mathbb{F}}_q$ is $\mathbb{F}_q$, and that of $\sigma^n$ is $\mathbb{F}_{q^n}$.
- In sections 2 and 3, an elliptic curve $E$ over $\mathbb{F}_q$, given by a Weierstrass equation with coefficients in $\mathbb{F}_q$.
- The ring $\mathrm{End}(E)$ of the endomorphisms of $E$ *defined over* $\mathbb{F}_q$.
- The $q$-power Frobenius endomorphism

$$\mathsf{F}\colon E \to E, \qquad (x, y) \mapsto (x^q, y^q).$$

- The integers

$$a \coloneqq q + 1 - \#E(\mathbb{F}_q), \qquad a_n \coloneqq q^n + 1 - \#E(\mathbb{F}_{q^n}) \quad (n \geqslant 1), \qquad a_0 \coloneqq 2,$$

  so that $a_1 = a$.
- For a prime $\ell \neq p$, the Tate module $T_\ell(E) = \varprojlim_n E[\ell^n](\overline{\mathbb{F}}_q)$, a free $\mathbb{Z}_\ell$-module of rank 2, and the map $\psi_\ell \in \mathrm{End}\big(T_\ell(E)\big)$ induced by $\psi \in \mathrm{End}(E)$.

**How to use this.** Allow about 25 minutes for §1, 35 for §2 and 20 for §3. In Problem 1.4 the heart is parts (2) and (3). Parts (5) and (6) can be done at home. Problems 2.1, 2.7 and 2.8 are the core of §2. Problem 2.9 is short, and Problem 2.10 is a computation to finish at home. In Problem 3.4, part (1) is quick, and the case analysis in parts (4) and (5) is the point of the problem. The `Magma` parts need no time in the session: do the hand work there and run the code afterwards, as a check on what you wrote. Every block returns in a few seconds.

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## 1. Zeta functions and closed points

Let $C$ be a smooth projective curve over $\mathbb{F}_q$. The zeta function of $C$ (Definition 1.2) packages the numbers of rational points over all the extensions of $\mathbb{F}_q$ into one power series. The exponential in it looks odd: the more obvious series is $\sum_n \#C(\mathbb{F}_{q^n})T^n$. Problem 1.4 explains the choice. It is [Poo06, Proposition 3.4.3 and Exercise 3.7]. In [Poo06] the ground field is perfect throughout, as $\mathbb{F}_q$ is.

**Definition 1.1** (Closed points [Poo06, Definition 2.2.1])**.** A closed point $P$ of $C$ is an integral subvariety of dimension 0. Its residue field $\mathbb{F}_q(P)$ is a finite extension of $\mathbb{F}_q$, and its degree is $\deg P \coloneqq [\mathbb{F}_q(P) : \mathbb{F}_q]$.

**Definition 1.2** (The zeta function)**.** The zeta function of $C$ is

$$Z(C/\mathbb{F}_q; T) \coloneqq \exp\Big(\sum_{n\geqslant 1} \#C(\mathbb{F}_{q^n})\frac{T^n}{n}\Big) \in \mathbb{Q}[[T]],$$

so that $\#C(\mathbb{F}_{q^n})$ is the coefficient of $T^{n-1}$ in $\frac{d}{dT}\log Z(C/\mathbb{F}_q; T)$.

**Proposition 1.3** (Closed points are Galois orbits [Poo06, Remark 2.2.2])**.** *Sending a point of $C(\overline{\mathbb{F}}_q)$ to its image is a surjection from $C(\overline{\mathbb{F}}_q)$ onto the set of closed points of $C$, whose fibers are the $\mathrm{Gal}_{\mathbb{F}_q}$-orbits. The orbit over a closed point $P$ has $\deg P$ elements: a point of $C(\overline{\mathbb{F}}_q)$ over $P$ is an $\mathbb{F}_q$-embedding $\mathbb{F}_q(P) \hookrightarrow \overline{\mathbb{F}}_q$, and there are $\deg P$ of these.*

**Problem 1.4** (The Euler product)**.**
For $d \geqslant 1$, let $N_d$ be the number of closed points of $C$ of degree $d$.
(1) Show that a point of $C(\overline{\mathbb{F}}_q)$ lies in $C(\mathbb{F}_{q^n})$ if and only if $\sigma^n$ fixes it. Deduce that a $\mathrm{Gal}_{\mathbb{F}_q}$-orbit of size $d$ is contained in $C(\mathbb{F}_{q^n})$ if $d \mid n$, and is disjoint from it otherwise.
(2) Show that $N_d$ is finite, and that

$$\#C(\mathbb{F}_{q^n}) = \sum_{d|n} dN_d \qquad \text{for every } n \geqslant 1.$$

(3) Deduce the identity of formal power series

$$Z(C/\mathbb{F}_q; T) = \prod_P \big(1 - T^{\deg P}\big)^{-1} = \prod_{d\geqslant 1}(1 - T^d)^{-N_d},$$

the first product running over the closed points $P$ of $C$. Why is the product well defined? Conclude that $Z(C/\mathbb{F}_q; T) \in 1 + T\mathbb{Z}[[T]]$, which is not obvious from the exponential.
(4) Invert (2): show that $N_d = \frac{1}{d}\sum_{e|d}\mu(d/e)\,\#C(\mathbb{F}_{q^e})$, where $\mu$ is the Möbius function. So the numbers of rational points over the extensions of $\mathbb{F}_q$ and the numbers of closed points of each degree determine each other.
(5) Take $C = \mathbb{P}^1$. Show that $Z(\mathbb{P}^1/\mathbb{F}_q; T) = 1/\big((1-T)(1-qT)\big)$. The closed points of $\mathbb{P}^1$ are the point at infinity, of degree 1, and the closed points of $\mathbb{A}^1$, which are the monic irreducible polynomials $f \in \mathbb{F}_q[t]$, with $\deg P = \deg f$. Deduce that the number of monic irreducible polynomials of degree $d$ over $\mathbb{F}_q$ is $\frac{1}{d}\sum_{e|d}\mu(d/e)q^e$. How many are there of degree 2 over $\mathbb{F}_2$, and which are they?
(6) Put $\zeta_C(s) \coloneqq Z(C/\mathbb{F}_q; q^{-s})$ and $NP \coloneqq \#\mathbb{F}_q(P)$. Show that $\zeta_C(s) = \prod_P \big(1 - NP^{-s}\big)^{-1}$, and compare with the Euler product $\zeta(s) = \prod_p (1-p^{-s})^{-1}$ of the Riemann zeta function.

**Remark 1.5** (The Weil conjectures for curves)**.** Let $C$ be a smooth projective curve of genus $g$ over $\mathbb{F}_q$. The Weil conjectures (proved for curves by Weil) say:

(1) (Rationality) $Z(C/\mathbb{F}_q;T) = P(T)/\big((1-T)(1-qT)\big)$ with $P \in \mathbb{Z}[T]$ of degree $2g$ and $P(0)=1$.
(2) (Functional equation) $Z\big(C/\mathbb{F}_q;1/(qT)\big) = q^{1-g}T^{2-2g}Z(C/\mathbb{F}_q;T)$.
(3) (Riemann hypothesis) $P(T) = \prod_{i=1}^{2g}(1-\alpha_i T)$ with $|\alpha_i| = \sqrt{q}$ for every $i$.

For $C = \mathbb{P}^1$, of genus 0, Problem 1.4(5) gives all three with $P = 1$. We prove them for $g = 1$ in section 2.

## 2. The zeta function of an elliptic curve

Problem 2.1 is [Sil09, Exercise 5.3].

**Problem 2.1** (Traces and determinants)**.**
Let $A$ be a square matrix over a field $K$ of characteristic 0. We prove, in two ways, that

$$\exp\Big(\sum_{n\geqslant 1}\operatorname{tr}(A^n)\frac{T^n}{n}\Big) = \frac{1}{\det(1-AT)} \qquad \text{in } K[[T]]. \tag{2.1}$$

(1) Let $f, g \in 1+TK[[T]]$. Show that $f$ and $g$ are units of $K[[T]]$, so that their logarithmic derivatives $f'/f$ and $g'/g$ are defined, and that if $f'/f = g'/g$, then $f = g$.[a] Where do you use that $K$ has characteristic 0? Give a counterexample in characteristic $p$.
(2) Show that both sides of (2.1) lie in $1+TK[[T]]$, compute their logarithmic derivatives, and conclude with (1).[b]
(3) Give a second proof: triangularize $A$ over an algebraic closure $\bar{K}$ of $K$, reduce (2.1) to the case of a $1\times 1$ matrix $A = (\lambda)$, and prove that case with (1), applied over $\bar{K}$.

[a] *Hint:* compute the derivative of $f/g$.
[b] *Hint:* for $M(T)$ an invertible matrix over $K[[T]]$, $\frac{d}{dT}\det M(T) = \det M(T)\ \operatorname{tr}\big(M(T)^{-1}M'(T)\big)$.

Problem 2.7 is the proof of [Sil09, Theorems V.2.3.1 and V.2.4], arranged around Problem 2.1. In the following results, $E$ is an elliptic curve over $\mathbb{F}_q$ and $\ell \neq p$ is a prime.

**Proposition 2.2** (Frobenius is purely inseparable [Sil09, Proposition II.2.11])**.** *The Frobenius endomorphism* $\mathsf{F}$ *is purely inseparable of degree* $q$*.*

**Corollary 2.3** ($1-\mathsf{F}$ is separable [Sil09, Corollary III.5.5])**.** *The endomorphism* $1-\mathsf{F}$ *is separable.*

**Theorem 2.4** (Kernels of separable isogenies [Sil09, Theorem III.4.10(c)])**.** *A nonzero separable isogeny* $\psi$ *satisfies* $\#\ker\psi = \deg\psi$*, where* $\ker\psi$ *is taken in* $E(\overline{\mathbb{F}}_q)$*.*

**Proposition 2.5** (Determinant and trace on $T_\ell(E)$ [Sil09, Proposition III.8.6])**.** *For* $\psi \in \operatorname{End}(E)$*,* $\det\psi_\ell = \deg\psi$ *and* $\operatorname{tr}\psi_\ell = 1+\deg\psi-\deg(1-\psi)$*.*

**Theorem 2.6** (Endomorphisms act faithfully on $T_\ell(E)$ [Sil09, Theorem III.7.4])**.** *The map* $\psi \mapsto \psi_\ell$ *is an injective ring homomorphism* $\operatorname{End}(E) \to \operatorname{End}\big(T_\ell(E)\big)$*.*

**Problem 2.7** (The zeta function of $E$)**.**
(1) Show that $\sigma(Q) = \mathsf{F}(Q)$ for every $Q \in E(\overline{\mathbb{F}}_q)$. Deduce that the closed points of $E$ of degree $d$ are the $\mathsf{F}$-orbits of size $d$ in $E(\overline{\mathbb{F}}_q)$, and that $E(\mathbb{F}_{q^n}) = \ker(1-\mathsf{F}^n)$.
(2) Show that $\mathsf{F}^n$ is the $q^n$-power Frobenius endomorphism of $E$ over $\mathbb{F}_{q^n}$, and deduce that

$$\#E(\mathbb{F}_{q^n}) = \deg(1-\mathsf{F}^n) = \det(1-\mathsf{F}_\ell^n) = 1-\operatorname{tr}(\mathsf{F}_\ell^n)+q^n.$$

Where does the argument use that $1-\mathsf{F}^n$ is separable?
(3) Taking $n=1$, show that the characteristic polynomial of $\mathsf{F}_\ell$ is $T^2-aT+q$. In particular it has integer coefficients and does not depend on $\ell$.

(4) Use Problem 2.1 to show that

$$Z(E/\mathbb{F}_q;T) = \frac{\det(1-\mathsf{F}_\ell T)}{(1-T)(1-qT)} = \frac{1-aT+qT^2}{(1-T)(1-qT)}.$$

By Problem 1.4, this is also $\prod_P (1-T^{\deg P})^{-1}$ over the closed points $P$ of $E$.
(5) Verify the functional equation $Z\big(E/\mathbb{F}_q;1/(qT)\big) = Z(E/\mathbb{F}_q;T)$ of Remark 1.5.

**Problem 2.8** (The Riemann hypothesis and Hasse's bound)**.**
Let $\alpha, \beta \in \mathbb{C}$ be the roots of $T^2 - aT + q$, so that $1 - aT + qT^2 = (1-\alpha T)(1-\beta T)$.
(1) For $r, s \in \mathbb{Z}$ with $s \neq 0$, show that $\det(r/s - \mathsf{F}_\ell) = \deg(r - s\mathsf{F})/s^2 \geqslant 0$. Deduce that $T^2 - aT + q$ is nonnegative on $\mathbb{R}$, and hence that $\beta = \bar{\alpha}$ and $|\alpha| = |\beta| = \sqrt{q}$. This is the Riemann hypothesis of Remark 1.5. With $\zeta_E$ as in Problem 1.4(6), show that every zero of $\zeta_E(s)$ satisfies $\mathrm{Re}(s) = 1/2$, and that $\zeta_E(s) = \zeta_E(1-s)$.
(2) Show that $a_n = \alpha^n + \beta^n$ for every $n \geqslant 0$. Deduce Hasse's bound

$$|\#E(\mathbb{F}_q) - q - 1| \leqslant 2\sqrt{q},$$

and more generally $|a_n| \leqslant 2q^{n/2}$ for every $n \geqslant 1$.
(3) Conversely, suppose only that there is a constant $c$ with $|a_n| \leqslant c\, q^{n/2}$ for all $n \geqslant 1$. Show that the power series $\sum_{n\geqslant 1} a_n T^n = \frac{\alpha T}{1-\alpha T} + \frac{\beta T}{1-\beta T}$ converges for $|T| < q^{-1/2}$, and deduce that $|\alpha| = |\beta| = \sqrt{q}$. So the Riemann hypothesis is equivalent to a Hasse bound over every extension of $\mathbb{F}_q$, even with a worse constant.

Problem 2.9 is [Sil09, Exercise 5.13].

**Problem 2.9** (A recurrence)**.**
(1) Show that the single number $\#E(\mathbb{F}_q)$ determines $\#E(\mathbb{F}_{q^n})$ for every $n \geqslant 1$.
(2) Prove that

$$a_{n+2} = a_1 a_{n+1} - q a_n \qquad \text{for all } n \geqslant 0.$$

(Recall the convention $a_0 = 2$.)
(3) Here is the recurrence on $y^2 = x^3 + x + 1$ over $\mathbb{F}_{101}$:

```
q := 101;  E := EllipticCurve([GF(q) | 1, 1]);          // y^2 = x^3 + x + 1
a := [TraceOfFrobenius(ChangeRing(E, GF(q^n))) : n in [1..6]];
a;                                  // [ -3, -193, 882, 16847, -139623, -1282678 ]
b := [2, a[1]];
for n in [1..5] do Append(~b, a[1]*b[n+1] - q*b[n]); end for;
b[2..7] eq a;                       // true
```

Here `TraceOfFrobenius(E)` is $a$. Compute $a_2$ by hand from $a_1 = -3$. Check Hasse's bound for $a_6$ over $\mathbb{F}_{101^6}$.

**Problem 2.10** (A zeta function by hand)**.**
Let $E$ be the elliptic curve $y^2 + xy = x^3 + 1$ over $\mathbb{F}_2$ (its discriminant is 1).
(1) List the rational points of $E(\mathbb{F}_2)$, and find $a$.
(2) Write down $Z(E/\mathbb{F}_2;T)$, and check the Riemann hypothesis for it directly.

(3) Use Problem 2.9 to predict $\#E(\mathbb{F}_4)$ and $\#E(\mathbb{F}_8)$. Check the first by listing the rational points of $E(\mathbb{F}_4)$, where $\mathbb{F}_4 = \{0, 1, \omega, \omega^2\}$ with $\omega^2 = \omega + 1$.[a]
(4) Use Problem 1.4(4) to find the numbers $N_1$, $N_2$, $N_3$ of closed points of $E$ of degree 1, 2 and 3. Deduce that every $\mathbb{F}_8$-rational point of $E$ is $\mathbb{F}_2$-rational. Is $\#E(\mathbb{F}_8)$ close to the edge of the Hasse interval?
(5) Check the Euler product of Problem 1.4(3) against (2) up to the term in $T^2$.
(6) Check, where `Places(E, d)` lists the closed points of degree $d$:

```
E := EllipticCurve([GF(2) | 1, 0, 0, 0, 1]);            // y^2 + xy = x^3 + 1
[#ChangeRing(E, GF(2^n)) : n in [1..8]];     // [ 4, 8, 4, 16, 44, 56, 116, 288 ]
[#Places(E, d) : d in [1..6]];               // [ 4, 2, 0, 2, 8, 8 ]
ZetaFunction(E);             // (2*$.1^2 + $.1 + 1)/(2*$.1^2 - 3*$.1 + 1)
```

[a] *Hint:* for $x \neq 0$, substitute $y = xz$.

## 3. Isogenous curves

Problem 3.4 is [Sil09, Exercise 5.4]. Let $E_1$ and $E_2$ be elliptic curves over $\mathbb{F}_q$, with $q$-power Frobenius endomorphisms $\mathsf{F}_1$ and $\mathsf{F}_2$ and traces $a(E_1)$, $a(E_2)$.

**Definition 3.1** (Isogenies and Galois-equivariant maps)**.** We write $\mathrm{Hom}(E_1, E_2)$ for the isogenies $E_1 \to E_2$ *defined over* $\mathbb{F}_q$. The Galois group $\mathrm{Gal}_{\mathbb{F}_q}$ acts on each Tate module $T_\ell(E_i)$, and we write $\mathrm{Hom}_{\mathrm{Gal}_{\mathbb{F}_q}}\big(T_\ell(E_1), T_\ell(E_2)\big)$ for the $\mathbb{Z}_\ell$-linear maps that commute with this action.

**Theorem 3.2** (Tate's isogeny theorem [Sil09, Theorem III.7.7(a)])**.** *Let $\ell \neq p$ be prime. The natural map*

$$\mathrm{Hom}(E_1, E_2) \otimes \mathbb{Z}_\ell \to \mathrm{Hom}_{\mathrm{Gal}_{\mathbb{F}_q}}\big(T_\ell(E_1), T_\ell(E_2)\big)$$

*is an isomorphism.*

**Corollary 3.3** (Isogenies form a free module [Sil09, Corollary III.7.5])**.** *The group* $\mathrm{Hom}(E_1, E_2)$ *is a free $\mathbb{Z}$-module of finite rank, being a subgroup of the free module of.*

**Problem 3.4** (Isogenous curves have the same number of rational points)**.**
(1) Let $\varphi\colon E_1 \to E_2$ be a nonzero isogeny defined over $\mathbb{F}_q$. Show that $\varphi \circ \mathsf{F}_1 = \mathsf{F}_2 \circ \varphi$, and deduce that $\#E_1(\mathbb{F}_q) = \#E_2(\mathbb{F}_q)$.
(2) Deduce that $Z(E_1/\mathbb{F}_q; T) = Z(E_2/\mathbb{F}_q; T)$.

For the converse, suppose that $\#E_1(\mathbb{F}_q) = \#E_2(\mathbb{F}_q)$, so that $\mathsf{F}_{1,\ell}$ and $\mathsf{F}_{2,\ell}$ have the same characteristic polynomial $f(T) = T^2 - aT + q$ (Problem 2.7(3)). Fix a prime $\ell \neq p$ and put $V_i := T_\ell(E_i) \otimes \mathbb{Q}_\ell$.

(3) Show that a $\mathbb{Z}_\ell$-linear map $T_\ell(E_1) \to T_\ell(E_2)$ commutes with the action of $\mathrm{Gal}_{\mathbb{F}_q}$ if and only if it intertwines $\mathsf{F}_{1,\ell}$ and $\mathsf{F}_{2,\ell}$.
(4) Suppose $a^2 \neq 4q$. Show that $\mathsf{F}_{1,\ell}$ is not a scalar, that $V_1$ has a basis $v, \mathsf{F}_{1,\ell}v$, and that $V_1 \cong \mathbb{Q}_\ell[T]/(f)$ as $\mathbb{Q}_\ell[T]$-modules, with $T$ acting by $\mathsf{F}_{1,\ell}$. Deduce that there is a nonzero $\mathbb{Z}_\ell$-linear map $T_\ell(E_1) \to T_\ell(E_2)$ intertwining the two Frobenius maps.
(5) Suppose $a^2 = 4q$. Show that $q$ is a square, that $a/2 \in \mathbb{Z}$, and that $\mathsf{F}_i = [a/2]$ in $\mathrm{End}(E_i)$ for $i = 1, 2$.[a] Deduce that every $\mathbb{Z}_\ell$-linear map $T_\ell(E_1) \to T_\ell(E_2)$ intertwines the two Frobenius maps.
(6) Use Theorem 3.2 to conclude that $E_1$ and $E_2$ are isogenous over $\mathbb{F}_q$.

[a] *Hint:* compute $\deg(\mathsf{F}_i - [a/2])$ with Proposition 2.5.

**Remark 3.5.** Together with Problem 2.7(4), Problem 3.4 says that for elliptic curves $E_1$, $E_2$ over $\mathbb{F}_q$ the following are equivalent: $E_1$ and $E_2$ are isogenous over $\mathbb{F}_q$; $\#E_1(\mathbb{F}_q) = \#E_2(\mathbb{F}_q)$; $Z(E_1/\mathbb{F}_q; T) = Z(E_2/\mathbb{F}_q; T)$; and $E_1$ and $E_2$ have the same number of closed points of each degree (Problem 1.4(4)).

**Looking ahead.** By Problem 2.8(1), $\alpha = \sqrt{q}\, e^{i\theta}$ for a unique $\theta \in [0, \pi]$, and $a = 2\sqrt{q}\cos\theta$. Fix an elliptic curve over $\mathbb{Q}$, reduce it modulo every prime $p$ of good reduction, and let $\theta_p$ be the angle of the reduction over $\mathbb{F}_p$. How are the $\theta_p$ distributed in $[0, \pi]$ as $p$ varies? That is the Sato–Tate conjecture. The product over the primes of good reduction of the factors $(1 - a_p p^{-s} + p^{1-2s})^{-1}$, the reciprocals of the numerators of the $\zeta$-functions of the reductions, is, up to finitely many factors, the $L$-function of the curve, the subject of the Birch and Swinnerton-Dyer conjecture.

## References


[Poo06] Bjorn Poonen, *Lectures on rational points on curves*, 2006. Lecture notes, March 5, 2006 version. ↑

[Sil09] Joseph H. Silverman, *The arithmetic of elliptic curves*, Second, Graduate Texts in Mathematics, vol. 106, Springer, Dordrecht, 2009. MR2514094 ↑